

About the Causal Systems Frame

This frame requires you to trace mechanisms — to show not just that something happens, but how and why it happens, step by step. The core analytical move is identifying a causal chain: what initiates the process, how the effect is produced, and what results downstream. The phrases below are collocated chunks anchored to each specific question. Use them as building blocks combined with grammar stems from the Causal Systems grammar sheet.

Trigger What initiates the causal chain — the policy action or condition that sets things in motion.	Mechanism How the trigger produces its effect — the step-by-step process connecting cause to outcome.	Downstream Effect What results at the end of the chain — often at a different scale or in a different domain.
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Key connectors for this frame: *this triggers...* · *as a direct result of...* · *the mechanism here is...* · *this in turn leads to...* · *the downstream consequence is...* · *what drives this effect is...* · *the causal chain runs from... to...* · *this amplifies / suppresses / accelerates...*

Q1 — Should schools integrate media literacy education into their curricula? (EDU)

Trigger	Mechanism	Downstream Effect
› mandatory curriculum integration › structured source evaluation practice › systematic misinformation exposure training › critical reading skills embedded in instruction	› students develop habitual source checking › false content recognition improves over time › reduced emotional susceptibility to viral misinformation › critical evaluation becomes automatic rather than effortful	› lower misinformation spread at population level › stronger informed citizenry over a generation › reduced effectiveness of foreign disinformation campaigns › healthier democratic discourse downstream

Q2 — Should the gig economy be more strictly regulated? (WRK)

Trigger	Mechanism	Downstream Effect
› reclassification of gig workers as employees › mandatory benefit provision by platforms › stricter labor law enforcement in gig sector › minimum wage floor applied to gig earnings	› platform operating costs rise significantly › some platforms reduce workforce or exit markets › remaining gig workers gain benefits but lose flexibility › traditional employers face reduced labor cost advantage	› gig labor market contracts in regulated jurisdictions › worker protection improves for those who remain › informal labor market expands as platforms exit › long-term shift in how contingent work is structured

Q3 — Should there be stronger antitrust laws to break up monopolies? (ECN)

Trigger	Mechanism	Downstream Effect
› forced divestiture of dominant market players › lowered barriers to market entry by regulation › aggressive merger review and blocking › prohibition of anti-competitive pricing practices	› new competitors enter previously closed markets › incumbents can no longer leverage market power to exclude rivals › consumer choice expands as price competition increases › innovation incentives shift from incumbents to challengers	› lower consumer prices over medium term › accelerated product and service innovation › reduced concentration of economic and political power › stronger small business ecosystem downstream

Q4 — Should governments implement stricter regulations on lobbying? (GOV)

Trigger	Mechanism	Downstream Effect
› mandatory lobbying disclosure requirements › cooling-off periods for former government officials › caps on lobbying expenditure by sector › public registry of lobbying contacts and outcomes	› corporate access to legislators is reduced › cost of influencing legislation increases for industry › public interest groups gain relative influence › policy outcomes shift toward broader constituency interests	› reduced regulatory capture over time › improved public trust in legislative process › more equitable distribution of policy attention › long-term reduction in perception of corruption

Q5 — Should governments implement sugar taxes on processed foods? (HLT)

Trigger	Mechanism	Downstream Effect
› price increase on high-sugar processed foods › tax applied at point of manufacture or import › revenue directed to public health programs › industry reformulation incentive created by tax	› consumer demand for taxed products decreases at margin › manufacturers reformulate to reduce sugar content › lower-income consumers bear disproportionate cost burden › substitution toward alternative products occurs	› reduced average sugar consumption at population level › lower obesity and type 2 diabetes rates over time › reduced long-term healthcare system burden › food environment shifts gradually toward lower-sugar options

Q6 — Should governments regulate the use of social media algorithms? (TEC)

Trigger	Mechanism	Downstream Effect
› algorithmic transparency requirements imposed › engagement-maximizing optimization restricted › harmful content amplification limits mandated › third-party audit of recommendation systems required	› platforms redesign algorithms to comply with restrictions › viral spread of emotionally provocative content decreases › users are exposed to less polarizing content › business model dependent on engagement metrics is disrupted	› reduced political polarization at population level › lower radicalization rates in algorithmically-driven communities › healthier public information environment over time › reduced platform revenue from engagement-driven advertising

Q7 — Should governments implement a carbon tax on all fossil fuel usage? (ENV)

Trigger	Mechanism	Downstream Effect
› price signal applied across all fossil fuel consumption › tax rate set to reflect social cost of carbon › revenue recycled to households or green investment › carbon price floor established by legislation	› energy costs rise for consumers and industry › investment shifts toward lower-carbon alternatives › fuel switching occurs in transport and heating › carbon-intensive industries lose cost competitiveness	› aggregate emissions decline over medium term › accelerated deployment of renewable energy capacity › structural shift away from fossil fuel dependence › long-term reduction in climate risk at national and global scale

Q8 — Should there be stricter international regulations on deep-sea fishing? (INT)

Trigger	Mechanism	Downstream Effect
› binding catch limits in international waters › prohibition of destructive bottom trawling › mandatory vessel monitoring and reporting › closure of critical marine habitat areas	› commercial fishing pressure on depleted stocks is reduced › fish population recovery begins in protected areas › bycatch and ecosystem disruption decreases › illegal fishing becomes harder to conduct undetected	› marine biodiversity recovers over decade-scale timeline › sustainable fish stock levels support long-term food security › ocean ecosystem services are preserved › global protein supply chain becomes more resilient

How to Use These Phrases

These chunks are not sentences — they are starting points. Pick one from each column and connect them with causal language from the Causal Systems grammar sheet. For example:

"Mandatory curriculum integration triggers a process in which students develop habitual source-checking behavior — and the downstream effect, over a generation, is a population that is significantly more resistant to foreign disinformation campaigns."

Three chunks. Two connectors. One complete causal argument. The mechanism column is the hardest — and the most important. Do not skip from trigger directly to effect. Trace the chain.

Scaffold feedback is diagnostic only — your score is always holistic.